

Is agriculture an occupation or a sector? Gender inequalities in a European context

Sally Shortall BSc, MSc, PhD¹ | Vangelis Marangudakis BSc, MSc² 

¹Centre for Rural Economy, School of Natural and Environmental Sciences, Newcastle University, Newcastle upon Tyne NE1 7RU, UK

²Analytical Services, Department for the Economy, 39-49 Adelaide Street, Belfast BT2 8FD, UK

Correspondence

Sally Shortall, Centre for Rural Economy, School of Natural and Environmental Sciences, Newcastle University, Newcastle upon Tyne NE1 7RU, UK.
Email: sally.shortall@newcastle.ac.uk

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Abstract

This article focuses on inequalities in agriculture in the European Union. We examine the mismatch between European legislation on employment and any rigorous interrogation of women's employment position in agriculture. Our central argument is that this occurs because agriculture is seen as a sector rather than an occupation. DG AGRI is responsible for European agricultural and rural development policies. DG EMPLOYMENT does not have oversight for the agricultural workforce in the same way as other occupations as the existence of DG AGRI means farming is less obviously understood as an occupation. There are no similar measures to address the under-representation of women in agriculture in the same way as for science, technology, engineering and mathematics occupations. We demonstrate that when agricultural policies are seen as relating to an occupation rather than a sector, it becomes clearer how agricultural policy discriminates against women.

KEYWORDS

agriculture, employment, EU legislation, inequality, women

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INTRODUCTION

This article focuses on inequalities in agriculture in the European Union (EU). We argue that gender inequalities persist because farming is understood as a sector rather than an occupation. By this, we mean that agriculture is understood as land that produces crops, animals, meets environmental targets and produces public goods. The constitution of the people who make these happen receives less attention.

A great deal of research has highlighted the various inequalities experienced by women in relation to agriculture (see e.g., Shortall & Adesugba, 2021; see various chapters in Sachs et al., 2021). This is a global phenomenon. Despite the very different contexts of gender equality in the developed world, compared to the developing world, there are many commonalities when it comes to the position of women in agriculture (Adesugba et al., 2021; Ball, 2020; Dunne et al., 2021; Sachs & Garner, 2017). Women have unequal access to land, unequal access to education, unequal access to finance and are under-represented in farming organisations (Dunne et al., 2021; Shortall & Adesugba, 2020). A considerable body of research exists that examines the many dimensions of these inequalities, and many organisations try to correct for the gendered impact, mainly in the Global South. The Food and Agricultural Organisation (FAO) of the United Nations has two indicators of gender equality when it comes to land; first, gender parity in land ownership and securing rights over land, and second, revising legal agendas to ensure women's legal ability to own land or control land (FAO, 2018). These two indicators are mostly applied to the developing world. In some cases, women do not have the legal right to own land, in other cases, there is no legal barrier, but customary law means women do not own land. It is similar in Europe where there are no legal barriers to owning land, but in this context, the term 'customary law' is not used; rather, it is explained by 'cultural norms' and 'normative expectations'. The outcome is the same.

In the EU context, the EU has been a progressive force advancing women's equality in the labour market (Guerrina & Masselot, 2018). European legislation has shaped equality for women in the labour market by impacting member state policies. Gender equality policy is very well-developed in Europe due to its inclusion in the original Treaty of Rome (Fagan & Rubery, 2018). The EU has used hard law and soft measures to achieve gender equality. Many feminists are disappointed at the performance of the EU in attaining and protecting women's equality (Jacquot, 2017). When austerity and financial crisis hit, women's equality diminishes as a priority goal for the EU, and economic and business goals take priority (EIGE, 2020; Rubery, 2015). Other feminists argue there is a growing gulf between the EU's rhetoric on gender equality and the reality of its practices. Nonetheless, it is recognised that the EU has produced a body of legislation that has normalised the idea of gender equality in the labour market (Guerrina & Masselot, 2018). It is also recognised that corporate culture is important, and representation on corporate boards is essential to change cultures and promote gender equality (Maume et al., 2019). In addition, the EU pursues specific measures in employment areas where women are under-represented such as science, technology, engineering and mathematics (STEM; European Parliament, 2021b). These measures are detailed in the next section of the article.

What then of agriculture and women's position in European agriculture? We will examine the mismatch between European legislation on employment and any rigorous interrogation of women's employment position in agriculture. Our central argument is that this occurs because agriculture is generally seen as a sector rather than an occupation. Direct payments, the support to agriculture, is paid on agricultural area farmed by the person who owns the land, and no attention is given to differences between people receiving direct payments. DG AGRI is responsible for

European agricultural and rural development policies. DG EMPLOYMENT does not have oversight for the agricultural workforce in the same way as other occupations as the existence of DG AGRI means farming is less obviously understood as an occupation. There are no similar measures to address the under-representation of women in agriculture in the same way as for STEM occupations. We demonstrate that when agricultural policies are seen as relating to an occupation rather than a sector, it becomes clearer how agricultural policy discriminates against women. We begin by detailing relevant EU legislation, 'hard' law and advancing equality for women in the labour market. We also give an overview of gender mainstreaming, the primary 'soft' measure promoted by the EU. Next, we give an overview of the common agricultural policy (CAP), the main EU policy dealing with agriculture as a sector. We then turn to the main body of the article where we map across key components of European legislation to agriculture. We focus on how European legislation on STEM emphasises changing the gender balance by countering 'serious obstacles' such as gender stereotypes, male-dominated workplaces, conscious and unconscious bias (European Parliament, 2021a); addressing gender segregation; encouraging new entrants to correct gender balances; increasing access to education; addressing the gender pay gap and women's representation on corporate boards. We conclude that EU legislation and measures have not actually treated agriculture as an occupation or in any way addressed the inequalities between women and men in the farming occupation. Instead, agriculture is understood as a sector. We further conclude that the future planned changes to the CAP will mean greater variation in gender equality in agriculture across member states.

ADVANCING OCCUPATIONAL EQUALITY BETWEEN MEN AND WOMEN: EUROPEAN LEGISLATION AND MEASURES

Overarching context and legislation

The EU believes that employment and occupation are key elements in guaranteeing equal opportunities for all and contribute significantly towards achieving equality between men and women (Council Directive, 2000/78/EC). There is a complex web of legislation and hard law, combined with aspirational soft measures to try to achieve occupational equality. A brief overview is given here. Article 3 of the Amsterdam Treaty 1999 integrated gender equality into the foundation of the community. It 'places an obligation on the community to eliminate inequalities and promote equality between women and men in all its activities' (European Commission, 2000, p. 21). The EU strategy for gender equality consists of a dual approach of gender mainstreaming and special measures. This means the inclusion of a gender perspective into all EU policies and programmes, together with specific actions in favour of women (European Commission, 2000), and these are discussed below.

The Council Directive 2000/78/EC establishing a general framework for equal treatment in employment and occupation is a particularly significant piece of legislation. It advocates eliminating inequalities and promoting equality between men and women. It calls for the creation of a level playing field and says that because of the scale of this task, it requires community action because it cannot be sufficiently achieved by the member states. It names the particular obstacles that must be addressed (Article 3: 1): conditions for access to employment and self-employment including recruitment; access to all types of vocational training; employment and working conditions including pay differences; membership of organisations of workers, particularly organisations that benefit members. This has led to a scrutiny of female employment rates,

the gender pay gap, childcare targets and specific measures to address gender segregation and women's under-representation in particular occupations (Fagan & Rubery, 2018). In addition, there have been calls for directives on the gender balance of corporate boards, which have had a mixed reception among member states (Jacquot, 2017).

The European bodies pay particular attention to occupations where women are under-represented and encourage measures to redress the imbalance. For example, the European Parliament's (2021a) resolution promoting gender equality in STEM education and careers maps out clear obstacles that must be addressed. It emphasises the role of gender stereotypes in STEM education and careers as constituting a serious obstacle to equality between men and women students, which subsequently widens the gender gap in the STEM job sector. The resolution discusses the need to address the barriers presented by male-dominated workplaces and conscious and unconscious bias. It highlights sociocultural practices as an obstacle to equality in STEM occupations. There is a call for the member states to invest in formal and non-formal education and lifelong learning for women to ensure access to high-quality employment and opportunities to reskill and upskill to prevent a vicious circle of gender segregation of labour. Emphasis is placed on increasing new entrants as a means of addressing gender imbalances. The resolution deems it of the 'utmost importance' to have more female role models and to increase the number of women in leadership positions, in decision-making and on corporate boards. Having women on corporate boards is in itself intrinsically important, but it also has trickle-down benefits for women in terms of employment outcomes and culture (Kowalewska, 2020, 2021)

GENDER MAINSTREAMING

In addition to 'hard' law, there are several 'soft' measures, not legally enforced which member states are encouraged to undertake. Resolutions are not legally binding but carry political influence and moral authority. The main soft measure is gender mainstreaming. Gender mainstreaming was launched at the Fourth United Nations Women's Conference in Beijing in 1995. Gender mainstreaming is seen as the most 'modern' and progressive approach to gender equality. While initial gender equality approaches focused on equal treatment (presuming the male position to be the norm), followed by positive action approaches (specifically focusing on women), both these approaches were seen as limited because they did not consider how the gendered structures through which equality measures were implemented actually prolonged inequalities (Daly, 2005; Prugl, 2010; Rees, 2005; Shortall, 2015). Gender mainstreaming is seen as the superior approach to gender equality because it turns attention away from individuals and their rights and focuses instead on the processes, norms and organisational practices that generate inequalities (Allwood, 2014; Bock, 2015; Daly, 2005; Shortall, 2015; Woodward, 2008). The European Institute for Gender Equality's (EIGE) website provides a comprehensive guide to the tools that are necessary to facilitate successful gender mainstreaming.

Both gender experts and EU institutions are critical of how effectively gender mainstreaming has been implemented. One of the main charges against gender mainstreaming is that what it is trying to achieve is not clear. Goals and objectives are not identified (Allwood, 2014; Woodward, 2008). Without aims and objectives, it is an empty concept (Verloo, 2005). Gender mainstreaming has tended to focus on training policymakers to ensure they understand how to do gender mainstreaming and fill out the appropriate forms and paperwork rather than a sustained clear statement of what gender mainstreaming any particular policy hopes to achieve. How is success measured? This is difficult to identify if the goal to be achieved is not stated. At the EU level, the

tools advocated by EIGE, such as training, undertaking gender impact assessments and gender budgeting are rarely adopted (EIGE, 2020; Lodovici et al., 2016). It has remained superficial and is often ignored at both member state and EU levels (Fagan & Rubery, 2018, p. 303). Furthermore, evidence suggests a backlash against gender equality at the EU level (Allwood, 2014; EIGE, 2020; Minto et al., 2020), partly explained by austerity and the financial crisis. The importance of EU legislation, 'hard' law, has been underlined by EU experts as member states are often reluctant, and EU legislation has been a force driving greater equality (Fagan & Rubery, 2018; Jacquot, 2017).

The EU adopted the promotion of gender equality and gender mainstreaming in the regulation governing the CAP in 2000. As a result, there was research on how effectively it had been implemented in agriculture, and several reports were commissioned by the European Parliament and Commission (see the special issue of *Gender, Place and Culture*, 2015; Bock, 2010; Dwyer, 2015; Franić & Kovačiček, 2019; Shortall, 2010). These studies repeatedly report the inequalities in agriculture, women's lack of access to education, under-representation in farming organisations, the paucity of new entrants and the lack of EU gender-disaggregated data. The general conclusion is that gender mainstreaming has not advanced gender equality. Some of these articles perpetuate the view that farming is a sector rather than an occupation, arguing that differences in CAP payments are 'gender neutral' and simply reflect the inequalities in the structure of agriculture (for instance, see Dwyer, 2015). This article now turns to examine agriculture as an occupation and map the employment regulations onto the CAP, which more clearly illustrates the inequalities in this policy. We begin with a brief overview of the CAP.

THE CAP

The CAP is a complex and at times a controversial policy. The main function of the CAP was originally to guarantee a minimum living wage to European farmers and to guarantee food supply and security. It has been criticised over the years for distorting agricultural production and prices, distorting trade relations and discriminating against poorer nations, having inbuilt inequalities between types of farming and regions of the EU and being excessively expensive (Matthews, 2019; Scown et al., 2020; Shucksmith et al., 2005). Successive reforms have tried to correct some of the anomalies and distortions of the CAP although it continues to be the most expensive part of the EU common budget at 37.4% in 2019, and 77% of that budget goes to the European Agricultural Guarantee Fund (EAGF), which is mainly income support for farms (European Commission, 2020) and is often referred to as Pillar I. This payment is paid on the basis of the acreage farmed, and until the current round of the CAP, Pillar I did not have national monitoring committees as payment was simply paid on the basis of land owned. Inequalities persist and 80% of direct payments go to 20% of farms (Matthews, 2019; Shucksmith et al., 2005). Pillar II of the CAP is understood as rural development, although many of the funding streams also relate to agriculture such as the agricultural knowledge and innovation systems (AKIS), farm advisory systems (FAS), farm diversification and some funding provisions for young farmers. The budget for the CAP is agreed upon as part of the Multiannual Financial Framework between the member states, the European Commission and the European Parliament. At the member state level, national farming organisations and unions are heavily involved in agreeing to the parameters of Pillar I of the CAP. At the EU level, the national farmers' unions are also represented and play an important role in agreeing to the parameters. COPA (representing farming organisations) and COGECA (representing co-operatives) are the main agricultural boards at the EU level. They are representative of the member organisations at the member state level. Agriculture is undergoing structural change and

adjustment because of drivers of change such as climate targets, environmental demands, securing new entrants to the industry and dealing with an ageing workforce. The CAP is a significant driver of change for EU agriculture.

The EAGF is a subsidy paid to an occupation, although it is understood as a payment to a sector. While the subsidy is paid on the basis of acreage owned or farmed, it is people who farm, and that is their occupation. Inequalities that exist in that occupation receive less scrutiny because direct payments are tied to the land. Now, we turn to our breakdown of the position of women in the sector, unconscious gender bias, gender segregation, the rate of new entrants, access to education and representation on corporate boards, and the unequal position of women in the occupation of farming becomes clearer as does the role of agricultural policy in cementing this inequality.

EU DOCUMENTS AND GENDER BIAS

The EU gender equality strategy (2020) calls on gender stereotypes to be challenged. It states that stereotypical expectations based on fixed norms for women and men limit expectations, choices and freedom and contribute to the gender pay gap. European documents relating to the administering of the CAP and the EAGF fund, in particular, perpetuate a stereotype of agriculture as a singular individual activity rather than a family occupation as is the case in Europe and farmers as men. For the purposes of receiving subsidies, only one individual can be returned as the 'holder'. The Farm Accounting Data Network's A to Z of methodology, 2018, refers to the farmer as a man, referring to '*his* own animals' (p. 111 emphasis added). The Council Regulation (EC) No 1217/2009¹ refers to the operator as the natural person responsible for the day-to-day management of an agricultural holding, and elsewhere refers to farming as an individual activity, reinforcing stereotypes that farming is the responsibility of one person's work. Describing a returning holding, it states it must be farmed by a farmer about to keep farm accounts and willing to allow the accountancy data from *his* holding to be made available to the commission. Research has repeatedly found that women are predominantly responsible for farm accounts (Shortall et al., 2017, 2022). Regulation (EU) No 1307/2013 of the European Parliament and the Council² repeatedly refers to farmers as men, the assets as *his* disposal, *his* aid entitlements and *his* declaration of eligibility. Cultural norms and gender stereotypes are not questioned, rather they are reinforced in European documents and legislation relating to the occupation of agriculture.

The European Court of Auditors (2021) assessed how effectively the EU gender mainstreams its budget. It makes reference to the gender-blind distribution of the CAP subsidy. In its response, the European Commission argues that the subsidy (direct payment) applies the principles of equality. It states that it is not specifically aimed at either men or women but rather at farmers (paragraph 85). This completely misses the point of the gender inequalities in the occupation, it is akin to saying that education is targeted at engineers, not men or women. Women's farms are smaller, generate less income and are often not eligible for CAP payments because there is a lower threshold, negotiated with farming organisations, below which small holdings are not subsidised.

GENDER SEGREGATION IN AGRICULTURE

While it is possible to speak generally about agriculture in the EU, it is important to be mindful of the vast regional differences between and within member states. There are differences in the

TABLE 1 Sole holders (directly employed by the farm) in 2016, in thousands

		Total	Male	Female	% of Women
EU15 ^a	Total	4,117	2,932	1,137	28%
	Small Holdings ^b	1,927	1,246	681	35%
	Larger Holdings ^c	1,239	1,037	201	16%
New member states	Total	5,919	4,002	1,917	33%
	Small Holdings ^b	5,009	3,268	1,741	35%
	Larger Holdings ^c	315	270	45	14%
EU28 ^a	Total	10,036	6,934	3,054	31%
	Small Holdings ^b	6,947	4,513	2,422	35%
	Larger Holdings ^c	1,576	1,307	247	16%

^aEU28 and EU15 gender breakdown excludes Finland because it does not have gender-specific data available.

^bEconomic size based on standard output in euro < €8,000.

^cEconomic size based on standard output in euro ≥ €25,000.

Source: Eurostat 2016 data, provided by Eurostat 2020.

size of holdings, production systems, how farming families are integrated into regional markets, education levels, full and part-time farming and seasonal variations in labour demands.

Farming is an unusual occupation in continuing to be a predominantly family business. There are 10.5 million farms in the EU and the majority (95.2%) are family farms. The EU uses the FAO definition of a family farm: ‘an agricultural holding which is managed and operated by a household and where farm labour is largely supplied by that household’ (Eurostat, 2019). Research has long shown the interdependence of family and farm. Family members, men and women, are active participants in strategies to ensure the future of the family farm (Shortall et al., 2022). Other research has shown that farms likely to be viable in Europe are those that can rely on underpaid or unpaid family labour (Vrolijk et al., 2010). A total of 93% of EU farms only use family workers (Eurostat, 2019). Many women work unpaid on farms that has subsequent implications for pension rights.

Official agricultural statistics only capture the work of family members who are formally employed on the farm. For most farm family members, including women, their work is unpaid and therefore under-reported by statistics (Alston, 1998; Brandth, 2002; Shortall et al., 2017, 2022). Although women contribute significantly to the farm labour force and farming activity, they are under-represented when it comes to being the farm manager. Farm managers are those responsible for running a farm. Only one person per farm can be identified as a farm manager. Often the farm manager is also the owner of the farm, but this need not be the case especially when the farm has a legal form (Eurostat, 2018), or when the farm is rented. There is considerable variation in the percentage of women holders/farmers by member states. In Latvia and Lithuania, it is close to 45%, and it is 34% in Greece, Portugal and Romania. In Denmark, the percentage of women sole holders was 5%, 10% in Germany and 15% in the UK. In all cases, women are more likely to be the sole holder of smaller farms. Table 1 illustrates more clearly that women are less likely to be the sole holder of large farms, and while there are generally more women holders in the new member states (NMS), there are few on larger holdings.

Previous research has shown that the CAP has a differential impact on the North and South of Europe, and more recently there is a West/East divide (Shortall, 2010; Shucksmith et al., 2005). The collapse of socialist agriculture throughout Central and Eastern Europe has unfolded

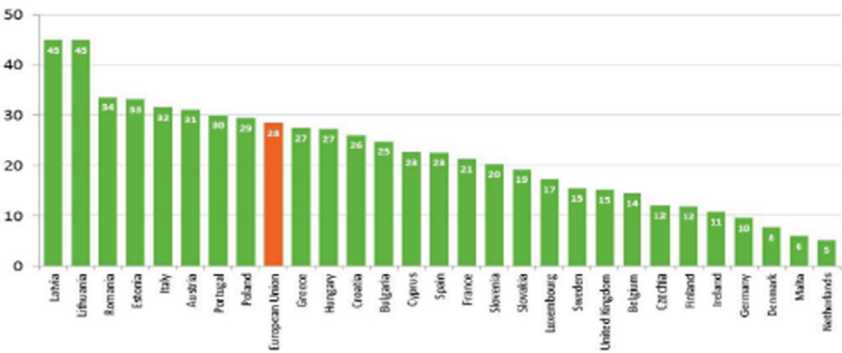


FIGURE 1 Proportion of female farm managers, 2016 (%). *Source:* Eurostat

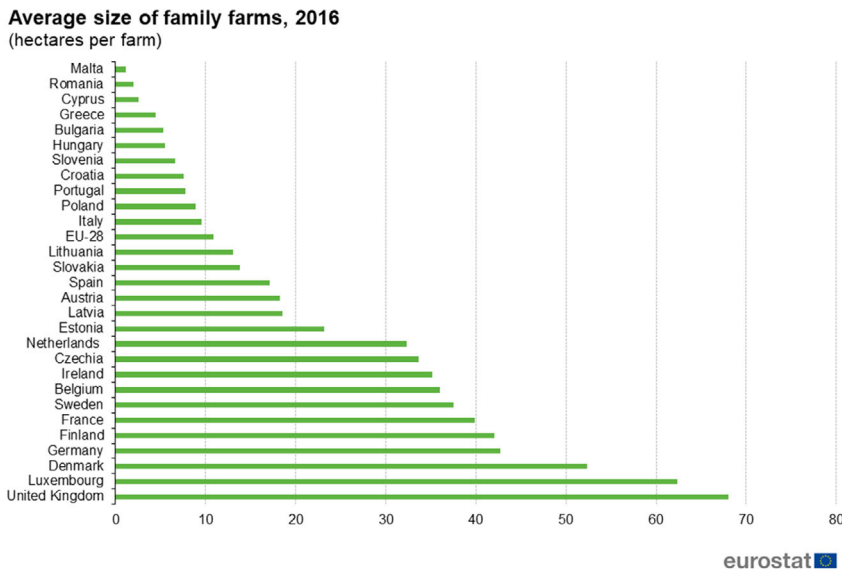


FIGURE 2 Average size of family farms, 2018. *Source:* Eurostat (Farm Structure, 2016)

in different ways in different countries, but in general, it has led to a proliferation of small subsistence-orientated holdings, and a high percentage of women are the holders of these units. There is something of a paradox to women's patterns of land ownership. The general trend for viable farms is towards fewer larger farms, yet women's higher rates of being the farm holder are directly linked to very small farming units that are less profitable. Figures 1 and 2 shows the average size of farms in the EU.

There is almost an inverse relationship between women's patterns of land ownership and the size of farms, with women owning few farms in countries with larger holdings and more in countries where holdings are very small.

Many EU documents have promoted the idea that there has been an increase in the number of women landholders with the figure currently standing at approximately 30%. This figure is somewhat deceptive. It is not so much that the number of women holders has increased, but rather the EU has expanded and many of the NMS have an increased number of women holders, but these tend to be on smaller, subsistence holdings, many of which are ineligible for CAP

payments. The increase in women holders actually reflects growth in inequality within agriculture. While DG EMPLOYMENT, SOCIAL AFFAIRS and INCLUSION monitor and address cultural norms and stereotypes that reduce women's presence in occupations and lead to gender pay gaps, this does not apply to agriculture. The income support payments are made without consideration at an EU level of whether there is a gender pay gap. The inequalities within agriculture are not scrutinised. DG AGRI distributes income support in a gender-blind way and views the support as going to farmers without considering the gender composition of the workforce. At an EU level, and for many member states, there is inadequate gender analysis of how the payments are spent. Ireland has recently launched a diversity strategy for farming and as part of this analysed direct payments by gender. They found that 92% of income support is paid to men (IFA, 2019).

The fact that DG AGRI distributes income in a gender-blind way is evidenced in the European Court of Auditors' report on how effectively the EU gender mainstreams its policies. It specifically comments on the EAGF:

The 2014–2020 Direct Payments Regulation does not include legal requirements concerning gender mainstreaming or gender equality. In our Opinion on the Commission's proposals for the post-2020 CAP48, we pointed out that a Member State concerned, for example, about the gender impact of direct payments will have 'few options' for changing how subsidies are distributed because the design of direct payments will largely be fixed by the proposed EU legislation. (p. 39)

The auditors further state that they found examples of this point in two of the four case studies they commissioned from an external expert.

Andalusia (Spain) applies gender budgeting in its regional budget. It uses around 90% of its programmes to promote gender equality. However, Andalusia's Agricultural Guarantee Fund is excluded, because the direct payments system leaves no scope for positive action regarding women. Sweden applies gender budgeting and has baseline data which demonstrates inequalities in agriculture. But the Swedish authorities explained that, because they implement the policy rather than designing it, and since gender budgeting is not mandatory under the Direct Payments Regulation, they cannot use it to correct inequalities'. (p. 39)

DG AGRI's response to these charges was as follows:

The direct payments regulation applies the principles of non-discrimination and equality between men and women enshrined in Articles 10 and 8 TFEU as well as in Articles 21 and 23 of the Charter of Fundamental Rights of the EU. It is not specifically aimed at either men or women but rather, at farmers'. (Replies of the Commission, p. 5, in European Court of Auditors, 2021)

This response underlines the fact that DG AGRI do not see farming as an occupation that should be scrutinised for gender equality in the same way as other occupations.

NEW ENTRANTS TO AGRICULTURE

The EU gender equality strategy (2020) is committed to challenging gender stereotypes that are a root cause of gender inequality. They limit choice and aspirations. There is a commitment to achieving equal participation across different sectors of the economy. The European Parliament's (2021a) resolution on STEM education and careers emphasises the importance of new entrants to correct existing gender imbalances. Now, we turn to examine the CAP's policy on generational renewal, including a Young Farmer Payment, and how well it promotes the EU commitment to challenging stereotypes and achieving equal participation across different sectors.

Entry to farming is unlike most other occupations. In farming, entry is most frequently through family inheritance of private property, either owned or rented. The type, size and economics of farming vary considerably across Europe. So too do the legal frameworks governing land transfer, with the British Isles governed by Common Law, the remainder of the EU by various expressions of the Napoleonic Code of Law, and Norway by Allodial law. Across these legal frameworks, there are no specific legal barriers to women's inheritance of agricultural land. Despite the wide variation in the economics of farming, and the legal frameworks governing land transfer, it remains the case that in general, men inherit the land. This shows the power and predominance of cultural norms. Male inheritance of land is the key factor shaping women's participation in agriculture and the public perception of farming as a male activity (Alston, 1995; Shortall et al., 2020).

Different EU member states have tried to address the cultural norm of male inheritance and widen the industry to women. In 1974, Norway introduced the Allodial law, which makes the eldest child the legal heir to the farm, yet only 12% of Norwegian farms are led by women (Eurostat, 2018). In Spain, there was concern that women were seen as family helpers and therefore not receiving the proper social, professional or economic recognition for their work. Even though women worked as co-managers of the holdings owned by their husbands, they did not appear as business partners. In 2009, The Ministry of Agriculture and Fisheries, Food and Environment introduced 'joint-titling' of holdings. The law on joint titling of agrarian holdings entered into force in 2012 and recognises married and non-married couples as co-holders who share the work, management, rights and subsidies of the holding. The law has however had limited impact (FAO, 2018, p. 59).

Eurostat reported that in 2016, seven in every 10 farm managers on the EU's 10.5 million holdings were men, and a majority (57.9%) were 55 years of age or more. Only about one in every 10 (10.6%) farm managers were a young farmer under the age of 40 years (see Figures 3 and 4), and this share was even lower among female farmers (8.6%; see Figure 3).

Europe's farming sector is dominated by an older population, and this is considered a threat to the viability of the industry going forward and a concern for innovation in the industry. This is even more pronounced when it comes to women farmers: Current data show that just 4.9% of farmers are women under the age of 35. Given that almost 40% of women working in agriculture are over 65 years of age (by contrast to just 27.6% for men), there is the potential for the gender gap in farming to widen in future years (European Commission, 2019).

New entrant women farmers tend to rent land (Shortall et al., 2020), as they rarely inherit if they have a brother. This pattern in many respects represents gender segregation; given women's unequal access to this occupation, the routes open to them to enter require having considerably more capital than men. The EAGF is gender-blind in terms of support for generational renewal and the Young Farmer Payment. It does not in any way try to encourage new entrant women. It does not use the fund to try and encourage equal participation in a very male-dominated

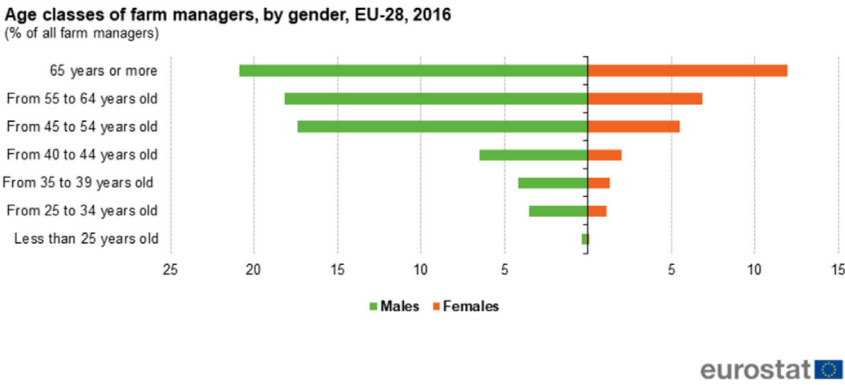


FIGURE 3 Age classes of farm managers, by gender, EU 28, 2016. *Source:* Eurostat (online data code: ef_m_farmang)

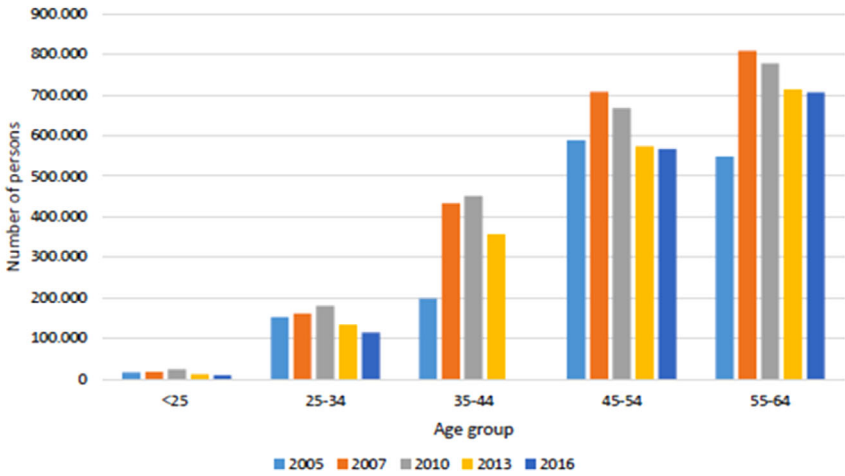


FIGURE 4 Generational renewal by gender: Total number of female farm managers by age class, 2015–2016. *Note:* Data for age class 35–44 in 2016 is not available. *Source:* Eurostat

workforce. The European Council of Young Farmers do not monitor new entrants to the occupation by gender. Measures to correct the gender imbalance in agriculture are not taken.

WOMEN AND ACCESS TO FARM EDUCATION AND TRAINING

There is no comprehensive EU data on women’s engagement with agricultural training provision, and what knowledge exists mainly comes from case studies and country-specific research (Dwyer, 2015; FAO, 2018; Knierim et al., 2017; Shortall, 2010). While some women undertake agricultural degrees, most of these go into farm-related activities such as agricultural advisers or farm secretaries. A great deal of agricultural training is ongoing life-long training, and research has consistently found that women participate less than men (Safilios-Rothschild, 2006; Shortall, 1996; Shortall et al., 2017). Agricultural extension workers and advisers often do not see women

as farmers and do not invite them to training initiatives or address programmes for their work (Barbercheck et al., 2009; Trauger et al., 2010). Women are often reluctant to attend training groups and see programmes as being for men and feel uncomfortable and conspicuous in this space. When women do access training, usually through women-only initiatives, they welcome the opportunity and find that it often validates the knowledge they have. Recent research for the Scottish Government found that many women would welcome farm training after 'marrying in' to a farm but felt too conspicuous to attend. Even active women new entrant women farmers were reluctant to attend and gained most knowledge through their agriculturally related employment. In 2018, the Scottish Government worked with the Farm Advisory Service (FAS), and women-only lifelong training sessions were offered. These were quickly over-subscribed showing the demand by women for training and the level of exclusion felt from existing provisions (Scottish Government, 2019).

The low levels of uptake of knowledge and advice measures are generally seen as a problem in Europe. There is a particular concern to advance knowledge of digital technologies with concerns that there is a risk of a digital divide with small and less educated farmers unable to keep up with new technologies. Recent research found that women and young farmers are generally underserved and not targeted by agricultural advisory service providers across Europe (Knierim et al., 2017). Research commissioned by the FEMM Committee (European Parliament Committee on Women's Rights and Gender Equality) found that female-operated farms tend to be significantly smaller, and female farmers are less well-educated and older than their male or corporate counterparts (Dwyer, 2015). While there is variation between member states, a higher proportion of female managers have practical experience only. It is concluded that these are all factors resulting in a gender disparity in beneficiaries of Rural Development Programme funding. This report recommended that knowledge transfer, advice and training be used to build capacity among farming women to improve their returns from the market and undertake farm diversification initiatives including tourism (Dwyer, 2015, p. 66).

Many member states recognise that there is a barrier to women accessing agricultural training and have taken measures to address this issue. Austria, Slovenia and Spain have some women-only training provisions (FAO, 2018). Often provision is ad hoc or develops because women agricultural advisers realise that they are not reaching women, even though they are part of the farm family business. The difficulty is that sometimes training for women is seen as a women's initiative and continues their status on the fringe of the occupation rather than participating in the mainstream.

At the EU level, considerable attention is given to enhancing knowledge and innovation in agriculture and rural areas through enhancing the AKIS. There is an awareness of the need for knowledge and innovation to be inclusive of older farmers, small farms and young farmers. There is no consideration of gender. AKIS is not monitored by gender (Dwyer, 2015). A report commissioned by the European Parliament's Committee on Agriculture and Rural Development (Shortall, 2010) and one commissioned by the FEMM Committee (Dwyer, 2015) both highlighted the need for more agricultural training to be targeted at women and for provisions to be inclusive of women. The European Economic and Social Committee (2018) underlines the need to invest in non-discriminatory and inclusive education systems. The European Parliament's (2021b) gender equality strategy underlines the importance of the digital inclusion of women. The AKIS in Pillar 2 and digital knowledge are both knowledge transfer and education for the farming workforce. Despite repeated reports demonstrating women's poorer access to agricultural training, this is not a priority for EU provisions.

REPRESENTATION IN CORPORATE BOARDS

The EU Gender Equality Strategy (2021) stresses that inclusive and diverse leadership is needed to solve the complex challenges decision-makers face. It is argued that diversity leads to better decision-making and corporate governance. Despite some progress, women continue to be under-represented in decision-making positions in Europe's businesses and industries (p. 13). To help break this glass ceiling, the Commission is pushing for the adoption of a directive on improving the gender balance on corporate boards. The report now turns to look at the representation of women on corporate agricultural boards at the EU level and the member states, primarily focusing on national and European farmers' unions who are the main boards representing the agricultural sector in CAP and EAGF negotiations. At the member state level, national farming organisations and unions are heavily involved in agreeing to the parameters of Pillar 1 of the CAP. At the EU level, the national farmers' unions are also represented and play an important role in agreeing to the parameters. COPA (representing farming organisations) and COGECA (representing co-operatives) are the main agricultural boards at the EU level, and they are made up of representatives from national farming organisations. The president and vice-presidents of COPA were all men until 2020 when the first woman president was elected. Seventy percent of COGECA's top tier are men. It is important to distinguish the administration of the organisations from the representative bodies, as the representative bodies are essentially the corporate boards and the administration of the secretariat. The Praesidium (executive committee) is over 85% men (researcher's own calculation).

COPA and COGECA have raised awareness of the existence of women farmers by providing the Annual European Innovation Award to women farmers who lead innovation since 2012. In some respects, the specific annual awards for women farmers and the specific women's committee serve to underline women's 'exceptionalism' in the industry. The awards do not constitute a specific measure to advance women's position in organisational representation. The Women's Committee does not advocate for greater representation or equality and there are no position papers on women or issues for women in agriculture.

The Praesidium is the representative body that negotiates policy with EU institutes, and it is in effect a very gender-imbalanced corporate board. It negotiates the terms of the CAP and agrees to the lower thresholds below which CAP payments are not paid. This lower threshold has a disproportionate impact on women farmers with smaller holdings. There is some evidence that women are better represented in organic farming, and if better represented, subsidies for organic farming could be framed differently. Research on European agriculture found that women's ideas for innovation are as marketable as men's, but they are not recognised by predominantly male stakeholders (Franić & Kovačiček, 2019).

In general, women are very under-represented in farming organisations in Europe, and this is reflected in the EU bodies. Several member states have tried to address this issue. The Austrian ZAMm (Future Agricultural Movitavion) training programme was created to tackle the dramatic sex imbalance in public representation at the national level. The programme is a joint initiative of the Ministry and the Working Group of Austrian Women Peasants. This Working Group is a national association founded in 1972 and represents the interests of around 130,000 women farmers. Coaching and mentoring are provided among other training provisions, and an equality charter was developed to try and remove structural barriers to women's participation. Despite the strong national organisation for women, the participation of women in relevant decision-making

bodies is very low. All nine Austrian chambers of agriculture have male presidents (FAO, 2018; Oedl-Wieser, 2015).

Almost all member states now have some women's farming organisations. The difficulties that arise are again that they tend to be seen as women's organisations rather than farming organisations. Most importantly, it is 'mainstream' farming organisations that are consulted in terms of policy matters rather than women's organisations.

It is not only that women are under-represented in farming organisations or corporate boards, but there is also evidence of direct discrimination. Women present at farming organisation meetings have at times been asked to leave at a point in the meeting and have been excluded from men-only farming dinners with clients and celebratory events (Shortall et al., 2017; The Telegraph, 2018). It is argued that this has numerous discriminatory impacts on women in agriculture, including denying women the opportunity to develop an occupational identity, which usually happens through membership in professional boards (Shortall et al., 2020).

It is essential that the absence of women on agricultural corporate boards is recognised in the same way as for other sectors. A proper analysis with published baseline data is necessary rather than an unconscious acceptance of the norm. The EU Gender Equality Strategy (2021) notes that if top positions are held exclusively by men for a long time, it shapes the recruitment pattern for successors due to unconscious bias. This requires attention in agriculture where the sustained absence of women reinforces cultural norms and stereotypes. There is a more significant outcome on gender equality for the CAP and the EAGF. The industry corporate boards, that is, farming unions, are heavily consulted at member state and EU levels on future agricultural policy and the policy formation of the EAGF, and these are almost entirely men. This limits dialogue about gender equality measures necessary to improve the position of women in agriculture.

CONCLUSION

The EU has successfully developed and implemented legislation that has normalised the idea of gender equality in the labour market and the expectation that where inequalities exist in particular sectors, these will be addressed. The main tools used are to address gender stereotypes, address gender segregation, encourage new entrants to address gender balances, increase access to education and ensure women's representation in leadership roles and corporate boards. Particular sectors, such as STEM, have undertaken serious initiatives to address the gender imbalance. 'Hard' laws have been most effective; 'soft' measures such as gender mainstreaming have been ineffectual.

Farming is not scrutinised for gender inequality in the same way as other occupations. We argue that because agricultural policies are the responsibility of DG AGRI, it is not monitored in the same way as other occupations. Instead, it is understood as a sector, that is land owned and used for animals, crop production and meeting environmental targets. Subsidies are paid on acreage; they are tied to the land rather than the people. We have shown that when the main tools to address gender inequalities in the labour market are applied to agriculture, gender inequalities become very evident and so too does the way in which EU agricultural policies cement these inequalities. The EU uses gender-biased language in its documents and speaks of farmers as men. The inequality in land ownership and the differential in size of farms and farm income are not monitored or addressed by the CAP. EU-funded agriculture education and knowledge exchange are not monitored by gender, and research commissioned by the EU has repeatedly highlighted women's needs for education and training. Corporate boards and representative farming organisations, negotiate

the terms of the CAP at the member state and EU levels, and these are overwhelmingly male. This is not scrutinised in any way. European agriculture corporate boards reinforce cultural norms and gender stereotypes of agriculture as a male industry and predominantly represent the needs of traditional male forms of agriculture.

There is a need for a sustained EU policy to address inequalities in agriculture, similar to those for STEM. Following the [European Court of Auditors' \(2021\)](#) report highlighting the gender-blind nature of CAP payments, the European Commission has instructed member states to take into consideration the women farmers when designing the CAP. It is a vague suggestion. All the evidence shows that EU legislation has generally led to better gender equality in the labour market of member states and has been particularly important in member states less committed to equality (Fagan & Rubery, 2018). Giving scope to member states to advance equality is likely to lead to greater variation between countries. Without EU legislation, it is likely to be ineffectual.

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CONFLICTS OF INTEREST

There are no conflicts of interest.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Data sharing is not applicable for this article as no new data were created or analysed in this study.

ORCID

Vangelis Marangudakis BSc, MSc  <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-3423-1996>

ENDNOTES

¹ Council Regulation (EC) No 1217/2009 of 30 November 2009 setting up a network for the collection of accountancy data on the incomes and business operation of agricultural holdings in the European community.

² REGULATION (EU) No 1307/2013 of the European Parliament and of the council of 17 December 2013, establishing rules for direct payments to farmers under support schemes within the framework of the common agricultural policy and repealing Council Regulation (EC) No 637/2008 and Council Regulation (EC) No 73/2009.

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